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Connecting Constituents with Federal Assistance for Broadband

This In Focus includes a list of selected federal agencies and programs that support broadband initiatives as the primary eligible funding activity. The programs included here vary in scope and funding level and are not a comprehensive list of all federal programs that may fund broadband activities.

Some programs award funds to state and local governments, which in turn may issue grant awards to other entities. Other programs make grant awards to eligible entities directly on a competitive basis. Interested applicants are encouraged to contact federal agencies, state agencies, or both for information on eligibility, the application process, award cycles, and funding availability. Each program's funding availability depends on annual appropriations. Where applicable, a program's website and assistance listing identification (ID) number is included to provide direct access to information about each program. The assistance listing IDs can be used to search assistance listings for potential open funding opportunities for the competitive grant programs at <https://grants.gov> and <https://sam.gov/federal-assistance>.

Federal Communications Commission (FCC)

The FCC directs the Universal Service Administrative Company (USAC) to administer the following programs. These programs provide subsidies or discounts for broadband-related services to eligible entities.

High Cost Program

The High Cost Program, also referred to as the Connect America Fund, provides subsidies through legacy (voice service) and modernized (broadband service) funds to eligible telecommunications carriers for services in rural areas that are unserved or underserved.

<https://www.usac.org/high-cost/funds/>

Lifeline Program

The Lifeline Program provides subsidies to telecommunication service providers to cover up to \$9.25 (or \$34.25 on tribal lands) toward the monthly costs of phone or internet service for eligible consumers. Eligibility is determined based on an income of no more than 135% of the federal poverty level or participation in a Lifeline-qualifying program as detailed on USAC's Lifeline Consumer Eligibility resource. Eligibility is limited to one beneficiary per household.

<https://www.usac.org/lifeline/get-started/>

Rural Health Care (RHC) Program

The RHC Program provides funding to eligible public or nonprofit health care providers for broadband to deliver health care.

<https://www.usac.org/rural-health-care/get-started/>

Schools and Libraries (E-Rate) Program

The E-Rate Program assists individual schools, school districts, and libraries with discounts on services under the following two categories:

- Category One: connectivity services to a school or library, such as telecommunications, telecommunications services, and internet access.
- Category Two: connectivity services within a school or library, such as internal connections, basic maintenance of internal connections, and managed internal broadband services.

<https://www.usac.org/e-rate/get-started/>

U.S. Department of Agriculture (USDA)

USDA's Office of Rural Development (RD) administers grant and loan programs to entities located in defined rural areas. Total population is the primary factor used in rural definitions to determine eligible rural areas for USDA RD programs. Each program includes information about the defined rural area. For additional information on eligibility, contact the USDA RD's state office. Information about USDA's broadband programs is available at <https://www.rd.usda.gov/programs-services/telecommunications-programs>.

Telecommunications Infrastructure Loans and Loan Guarantees Program

The Telecommunications Infrastructure Loans and Loan Guarantees program, also known as the Rural Telecommunications Loans program, provides loan and loan guarantees to state and local governmental entities—including federally recognized Tribes, nonprofit organizations, and for-profit businesses—for construction, maintenance, improvement, and expansion of telephone service and broadband in rural areas.

Assistance Listing ID 10.851

<https://www.rd.usda.gov/programs-services/telecommunications-programs/telecommunications-infrastructure-loans-loan-guarantees>

National Telecommunications and Information Administration (NTIA)

Tribal Broadband Connectivity Program

The Tribal Broadband Connectivity Program provides grants to eligible tribal or Native American entities for broadband infrastructure deployment projects, affordability support, distance learning, telehealth, and use and adoption of broadband efforts.

Assistance Listing ID 11.029

<https://broadbandusa.ntia.gov/funding-programs/tribal-broadband-connectivity>

Additional Resources

NTIA Resources

Additional federal funding opportunities and state broadband resources are available from NTIA's BroadbandUSA resources. BroadbandUSA is an online portal for NTIA to aggregate broadband funding, guidance, and technical resources for stakeholders seeking to expand broadband connectivity.

The "Funding Programs" web page provides an overview of the current and historical broadband programs administered by NTIA.

<https://broadbandusa.ntia.gov/funding-programs>

Updates about grant program guidance and webinars can be received by subscribing to the BroadbandUSA newsletter.

<https://ntiacrmgrants.my.site.com/broadbandusanewsletter>

The "State, Territory and Local Governments" web page provides information on the state and territory broadband offices, the State Broadband Leaders Network, and additional resources such as technical assistance guidance.

<https://broadbandusa.ntia.gov/resources/federal/state-territory-and-local-governments>

CRS Resources

For federal funding opportunities related to emergency communication initiatives, see CRS Report R45213, *Federal Grants and Loans for State and Local Emergency Communications Projects: Frequently Asked Questions*, by Jill C. Gallagher.

Regional commissions, each composed of member state governors and co-chaired by a governor and a federal appointee, receive federal appropriations for regional economic development, which may be used for infrastructure-related projects, among other purposes. For additional information about these commissions, see CRS Report R45997, *Federal Regional Commissions and Authorities: Structural Features and Function*, by Julie M. Lawhorn.

For general information about grants, see CRS Report RL34012, *Resources for Grantseekers*, by Maria Kreiser.

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